

Preliminary Documentation Plan

This plan describes the proposed content and work plan for:

Essay Writing in Word for First-Year College Students

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Issued by: Amy Flynn

English 380: Intermediate Technical Writing
University of Massachusetts Amherst

SUMMARY

The purpose of this plan is to explain the key elements and processes of creating the manual documenting the word processing software Microsoft Word for Mac, version 16.65. The manual will specifically focus on Word tools that could help first-year college students format various kinds of essays. It will not be explanations of how to write essays; rather, how to use Word to its fullest extent to create the type of well-formatted final papers that one would need for first year classes. The manual will be written with an emphasis on modular documentation, visual hierarchy, and task-orientation to maximize user experience. The final deliverables will be an approximately twenty-page, color-printed bound booklet, and an online PDF version available by December 8, 2022.

USER ANALYSIS

The intended audience of this manual is first-year college students. Though most likely this will primarily be young adults, the goal is that this will be usable for anyone starting college struggling with essay writing capabilities in Word. I spoke to current undergraduate students across a range of majors about their first-year experiences including economics, English, psychology, legal studies, biochemistry, journalism, and students that were undecided as freshmen. Questions asked were mostly about what kinds of written essays had to be turned in for first-year classes (especially not major specific ones), the styles of these documents, and what parts of Word formatting were/were not intuitive towards that end.

Most of the students interviewed did not have to write specific styles of essays but were required to have elements of different styles (i.e., a Works Cited and Table of Contents, but not specifically APA, Chicago, CSE, MLA, etc.). This seemed to be particularly true for first-year students because they typically take a range of classes, whether because they are undecided or because of general education requirements. Some common denominators among the group interviewed were page numbering (specifically starting on different pages than the first), cover pages, formatting works cited pages, and inserting/making charts. However, some students recalled very specific formats and issues: for example, the biochemistry major spoke about difficulty creating a Table of Reagents, the legal studies major spoke about annotated bibliographies, the psychology major spoke about APA style, and economics majors seemed to unanimously struggle with charts.

The general sentiment received by the students interviewed was that essay writing at a college level for the first time is inherently stressful, so navigating software that is not entirely intuitive is doubly frustrating and time-consuming. In the goal of generalizing the main issues and helping users with efficiency, the manual will be chronologically structured in the form of a generic essay-composing process with sections that focus on different features that have to do with different tasks. Though the manual will not be a style guide for different styles of essays, it will allow the user to know the functions of Word that can easily be applied for their specific purposes. For example, how to make a Table of Reagents will not be in the manual, but the process of creating and editing a polished table will be explained.

TABLE OF CONTENTS

1. Setting Up Your Document Pre-Writing
 - a. Adjusting Default Word Doc (2 pages)
 - i. Margins & text size, font, line spacing
 - b. Inserting Headers & Footers (1 page)
 - c. Numbering Pages (1 Page)
 - i. Specifically, not from the first page
 - d. Creating A Cover/Title Page (1 page)
 - i. Inserting blank page/page break
 - ii. Centering text in middle/center of the page (with page layout)
 - e. Creating A Table of Contents (1 page)
 - i. Automatic insert w manual option?
2. Inserting Pictures, Tables and Charts (with Captions!)
 - a. Inserting Pictures (1 page)
 - b. Inserting Tables (1 page)
 - i. Adding columns, table labels, formatting
 - c. Inserting Charts (2 pages)
 - i. Using premade template but also explaining customization
 - d. Captioning & Cross Referencing (1 page)
3. Citing Your References
 - a. Making Bibliography/Works Cited (2 pages)
 - i. Inserting automatically
 - ii. Making individual citations (potentially a callout)
 - b. Inserting Endnotes/footnotes (1 page)
4. Proofreading
 - a. Editing (1 page)
 - i. Spell Check
 - ii. Thesaurus
 - iii. Word count
 - b. Viewing (1 pages)
 - i. Viewing options
 - ii. Adding comments
5. Turning In Your Essay
 - a. Saving or Printing as Different Files (1 page)

Summary: There will be five chapters ordered chronologically in a generic essay-composing process, with fourteen task-specific modules in total. This will total to approximately seventeen pages. Including a cover page, title page, and acknowledgements, the total manual will be an estimated twenty-one pages. As the project is continued, I will have a clearer idea of this.

PROJECT SCHEDULE

EVENT	DATES	PEOPLE
Conduct User Research	Sep 22 – Sep 27	Amy Flynn
Upload draft of doc plan	Sep 29	
Submit A2: Final doc plan	Oct 4	Amy Flynn
Draft first third	Oct 4 – Oct 18	Amy Flynn
Upload draft of one module from first third	Oct 6	
Upload developed first third draft for workshop	Oct 13	Amy Flynn, class
Submit A3: Final first third + transmittal memo due	Oct 18	Amy Flynn
Mid semester check-in if needed	Oct 18	Amy Flynn, Janine Solberg
Draft second third	Oct 18 – Nov 8	Amy Flynn
Upload developed second third draft for workshop	Nov 3	Amy Flynn, class
Submit A5: second third (in color) + transmittal memo	Nov 8	Amy Flynn
Usability testing	Nov 8 – Nov 15	Amy Flynn
Upload usability memo	Nov 17	Amy Flynn
Draft last third	Nov 17 – Nov 29	Amy Flynn
Upload draft of introduction & develop printing plan for workshop	Nov 29	Amy Flynn, class
Submit final third (for completion)	Nov 29 (end of day)	Amy Flynn
Upload draft of cover design	Dec 1	Amy Flynn
Final workshop, bring full draft	Dec 6	Amy Flynn
Submit final manual	Dec 8	Amy Flynn

TOOLS, RESOURCES, AND RECEIVABLES

The work for this manual will be completed on my personal laptop, specifically for my Word experience research so that I am consistently representing Word for Mac version 16.65. Other than that, I can supplement with the computer lab or the library. Some human resources I will need are my classmates for workshopping, Professor Solberg for guidance, and first-year students for user testing. Given the industry standard of three to five hours per page of content, plus additional time for other pages and editing, I think I will spend approximately one hundred hours on this project (in total between in and out of class). The costs to me will be the final printing and binding of the manual, which I assume will be in the range of thirty to fifty dollars. I will be looking into Amherst Copy and Designworks's services for this.